

A Call for Arms

Tightening the noose on LTTE's maritime wing, Sri Lanka asks India for another warship to tackle ships smuggling ammunition

When the world was observing the sixth anniversary of the 9/11 attacks, a flotilla of Sri Lankan warships was engaged in a game of hide and seek in the Indian Ocean, close to the Indonesian coast. In a span of 24 hours, Lankan warships had tracked down three LTTE freighters laden with arms, including artillery shells, aircraft parts and reportedly a bulletproof vehi-

ships close to our coast. Now we have decided to target the mother ships (Sea Pigeons)," says a Sri Lankan official.

In August last year, two months after the 2002 ceasefire between the Sri Lankan government and LTTE had broken down, India had quietly transferred to it a second patrol vessel, the Coast Guard Ship (CGS) *Varaha* costing Rs 175 crore. The aim was to help the Lankan

succeeds in destroying the maritime and air capabilities of LTTE, because of the prospects of other groups emulating them," says security analyst B. Raman. India has aided the navy and the Lankan air force but abstained from helping the army for fear the arms could be used to target Tamil civilians.

The request for a warship has put the government into a quandary because it cannot transfer them openly to avoid inflaming public sentiment in Tamil Nadu. *Varaha*, for instance, was handed over to the Lankans, not in Chennai where the ship was based, but in Visakhapatnam, away from the media and public glare.

The Indian navy and the coast guard say they are facing a shortage of patrol ships, and simply cannot spare more of the kind Lanka is looking for. Also, new vessels are rolling out of Indian shipyards at too slow a rate for it to be an option for the Lankan Navy. It takes a shipyard between three and five years to build an offshore patrol vessel costing over Rs 200 crore.

Not giving Lanka a patrol vessel, however, means pushing them into the arms of China or Pakistan, who are eager to increase their regional footprint, much to India's consternation. National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan articulated this concern a few months ago, when he asked Lanka to approach India for its arms requirements. "It is high time Sri Lanka understood that India is the big power in the region and ought to refrain from going to Pakistan or China for weapons as we are prepared to accommodate them," he said. Though, he added, India could not supply 'offensive military equipment'.

Sri Lanka has been obtaining 'offensive equipment' for its army primarily from China and Pakistan. These have included multi-barrel rocket launchers, armoured personnel carriers and air-to-ground missiles—used recently to clear the LTTE from the eastern provinces. The final phase of the campaign is expected to begin with an assault on the Tiger bastion in the Wanni jungles of northern Sri Lanka. It remains to be seen what role India will play in ensuring the Tigers don't get their arms from the sea.

by Sandeep Unnithan



ON ALERT: *Varaha* (above); a destroyed LTTE freighter



HELPING OUT

AIR FORCE: India has provided Indra-II air defence radar to cover vital areas in the island nation, including Colombo airport, to warn of Air Tiger's light aircraft. Training has also been provided to Lankan Air Force personnel to operate the radar.

NAVY: Two offshore patrol vessels transferred to the Sri Lankan Navy, the *INS Saryu* in 2000 and CGS *Varaha* in 2006

INTELLIGENCE-SHARING: Tip-offs from India this year resulted in the sinking of two LTTE freighters off the coast of Sri Lanka

cle for its chief V. Prabhakaran. Leading the operation was the *SLNS Sayura*, a former Indian warship transferred to Sri Lanka seven years ago.

This remarkable operation, a first for the fledgling Sri Lankan Navy signifies a change of government strategy from 'brown water' (coastal) to 'blue water' (deep-water) operations. It is the world's only internecine war with a maritime element. "Earlier, we only intercepted the Sea Tiger boats that off-loaded ammunition from merchant

Navy conduct deep water operations, which have resulted in the destruction of nine such LTTE freighters in the past few years, five having been sunk this year alone.

Now, Sri Lanka says it wants a third warship to help tighten the arms blockade around LTTE. The request for a new warship was formally communicated to the Indian Government last fortnight, just days before it struck the Tiger vessels off the Indonesian coast.

"It is in our interest that Sri Lanka